

Japanese information operations and information warfare refers to the use of information, cyber, psychological, intelligence, and strategic communication capabilities by the government of Japan, the Japan Self-Defense Forces (JSDF), political actors, and non-state organizations to influence perceptions, protect information environments, and support national security objectives.

According to Japanese government strategy documents published in the 2020s, information, cyber, and cognitive domains have become increasingly important components of national security.

Background

Japan's modern information strategy emerged from a combination of public diplomacy initiatives, cybersecurity concerns, and regional geopolitical competition.

Following disputes with China over the Senkaku Islands, concerns regarding Russian information operations, and North Korean cyber activities, Japanese policymakers increasingly identified information space as a strategic domain comparable to land, sea, air, space, and cyberspace. Japan's 2022 National Security Strategy and related defense documents emphasized the importance of strategic communications, information superiority, and resilience against disinformation campaigns.

Government strategic communications

Since the mid-2010s, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has expanded programs devoted to overseas strategic communications. The government allocated significant funding under programs aimed at promoting Japan's international image and countering what officials described as misinformation regarding Japanese foreign policy, territorial disputes, and historical issues. According to budget documents, expenditures associated with overseas strategic communication programs increased substantially following 2015 amid growing

regional security tensions and disputes in East Asia.

Supporters describe such initiatives as a form of public diplomacy, while critics in China and South Korea have argued that some activities seek to reshape international perceptions of Japan's wartime conduct and regional security policies.

Military information warfare

Information Warfare Command

In March 2026, the Information Warfare Command (情報作戦集団) was established by the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force. The command consolidated intelligence, cyber defense, oceanographic intelligence, communications, and information-related functions previously distributed among several JMSDF organizations.

Japanese defense planners described the command as part of a broader transition toward multi-domain operations integrating naval, cyber, electromagnetic, and cognitive warfare capabilities. Analysts compared the organization to the U.S. Navy's United States Fleet Cyber Command and United States Tenth Fleet.

Cognitive warfare

Beginning in the 2020s, Japanese defense publications increasingly discussed cognitive warfare (認知戦) as an emerging security challenge.

Japanese defense analysts argued that foreign actors could manipulate public opinion through social media, online propaganda, disinformation, and artificial intelligence-generated content. Defense planning documents increasingly identified information influence activities as a component of national security strategy.

Cyber operations

Japan has significantly expanded cyber defense capabilities since the 2010s. The Ministry of

Defense established dedicated cyber units and increased personnel assigned to cyber defense missions. Japanese officials have frequently cited cyber threats attributed to actors associated with China, North Korea, and Russia.

According to reports by the Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS) and International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS), Japan has emerged as one of the fastest-growing cyber powers in East Asia.

Online nationalist networks

Researchers have documented the growth of online nationalist communities in Japan, including groups associated with historical revisionism and anti-Chinese or anti-Korean rhetoric. Organizations such as Zaitokukai and other nationalist movements have utilized social media platforms to disseminate political messages and mobilize supporters.

Scholars have argued that online ecosystems have amplified nationalist narratives while contributing to political polarization.

AI-generated content controversies

In 2026, Chinese state media cited reporting by Asahi Shimbun alleging that contractors recruited through crowdsourcing platforms such as CrowdWorks had been paid to produce content critical of China and supportive of Japanese nationalist viewpoints. According to the reports, some contractors were allegedly provided with content guidelines and encouraged to use generative artificial intelligence tools to create videos, social media posts, and articles.

The extent of coordination between such activities and Japanese government institutions remains disputed.

International reactions

China

Chinese government officials and state media have increasingly characterized Japanese strategic communications, historical revisionism, and anti-China narratives as components of a broader information warfare campaign. Chinese commentators have argued that artificial intelligence technologies have expanded the scale and effectiveness of such activities.

On 29 July 2026, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning responded to media reports alleging that Japanese right-wing groups had used artificial intelligence and paid online campaigns to produce and disseminate large volumes of disinformation intended to distort the history of the Second Sino-Japanese War. Mao said that China was "seriously concerned" by the reports. According to Mao, Japanese right-wing groups had failed to fully reflect on Japan's wartime aggression and had instead attempted to minimize or distort historical responsibility through actions such as visits to Yasukuni Shrine, revisions to school textbooks, and changes to museum exhibits. She further argued that the use of emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, to spread what China described as historical revisionism represented a greater threat than previous efforts and was linked to Japan's "remilitarization". Mao stated that such actions challenged the post-war international order and threatened regional peace and stability.

South Korea

South Korean media and political figures have similarly criticized historical revisionism in Japan and accused nationalist organizations of attempting to undermine international recognition of wartime atrocities.

See also

Cyberwarfare

Psychological warfare

Historical revisionism

Zaitokukai

2025–2026 China–Japan diplomatic crisis

== References ==